

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4**PART A Group Interaction**

Below is an extract about snakes from a Hong Kong magazine:

William Sargent, a Lantau Island resident, has had a fascination with snakes since he was twelve and he has caught and photographed thousands of Hong Kong's 55 snake species.

Fear

Contrary to common belief, Sargent insists that snakes are not aggressive and that the general lack of knowledge about snakes has led to much fear. Having said that, dozens of people are bitten by venomous snakes every year. Common reasons for snake bite incidents include:

- Walking through overgrown trails
- Walking on a dimly lit trail and stepping on an unseen snake
- Finding a snake and trying to kill it or pick it up

Education, not fear

Instead of fearing snakes, Sargent suggests that we should try to see them as part of the ecosystem just like any other creature. People need to learn more about them, he says, through online research and books or even speaking to people who have snakes as pets.

Sargent says, "I take visitors out in the field to photograph snakes. I train them how to look for snakes and how to get the best photos. Very quickly the reaction goes from 'Arrgh!' to 'Wow, that's a fascinating creature, I didn't know that' and 'Can I go with you again?'" So the next time you see a snake, remain calm, give it space, grab your camera and feel lucky that you have seen a fascinating creature that's just getting on with its day.

Your group is meeting to discuss whether to a) invite students to go on one of William Sargent's photography field trips or b) invite him to your school to talk about Hong Kong's snakes. You may want to talk about:

- which activity you prefer and why
- how you would promote your chosen activity in your school
- questions to ask William Sargent
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Are you afraid of snakes?
2. Have you ever seen a snake in Hong Kong?
3. Would you like a snake as a pet?
4. What would you do if you saw a snake?
5. Do you think students learn more from field trips or talks?
6. Do you think snakes would be difficult to photograph?
7. Do you think Hong Kong's wildlife should be part of the school curriculum?
8. Is a fear of snakes something people are born with or something they learn?